

2.1 Unit B601: Philosophy 1 (Deity, Religious and Spiritual Experience, End of Life)

Each of the faiths studied will be examined according to the issues specified below. Candidates should be able to explore the significance and impact of religions and support their answers with reference to the teachings, sacred texts, beliefs and attitudes of the faiths where appropriate.

In this unit candidates should reflect on the idea that religions have different approaches and attitudes and that there is diversity within each faith, its understanding of texts and its philosophy.

They should consider these issues in relation to the particular religion itself and to its impact on individuals, communities and societies, locally, nationally and globally whilst realising that these particular aspects may vary in significance between religions and communities.

They should also consider the extent to which the particular religion and belief being studied contributes to community cohesion.

Although the large variety of different philosophical and ethical views are not specified for each unit and whereas it would be too demanding for candidates to study a wide range of different views at this level, nevertheless they should be aware that there is diversity of belief and opinion within each faith.

The final part of each question gives candidates the opportunity to express not only their personal views but also their understanding of other religions and beliefs including Humanism, Bahai, Jain and Zoroastrianism.

2.1.1 Buddhism

Belief about deity

Nature of gods	• Beliefs about the nature of the gods • Reasons for views on the limited status of the gods
Belief in gods	• Reasons given in support of belief
Miracles	• Concept of miracles, including different beliefs within the religion • Gods, Buddhas and bodhisattvas intervening in the world and their relative importance

Religious and spiritual experience

Public and private worship	• Concept of worship • Worship in a vihara and at home • The use and significance of symbolism in worship
Meditation	• Concept of meditation • Its purpose and use to deepen faith



Food and fasting

- Concept of fasting
- Use of food and fasting as a spiritual discipline
- Food for festivals

The end of life

Body and soul

- Concept of anatta
- The relationship between the body and soul

Life after death

- Concept of reincarnation/rebirth
- Understandings of:
 - Samsara
 - Kamma
 - Nibbana
- Relationship between moral behaviour and future rebirths